There was little that Akbar did not see a divine hand in these days. Only a week or so after the fall of Kumbhalgarh, one of Akbar's elephants, Pundarik, drowned while crossing a river. Akbar rejoiced because loss of property meant an increase of life – a happy reading of the accident that Sadiq Khan, hauled up for letting an imperial elephant drown in the Ganga, might have rolled his eyes at.

It wasn't just good omens and prophesies that fell to Akbar like blessings from above. A greater gift was in store for him; and a greater shift in his own understanding of himself. Akbar was still touring Punjab when Pundarik met his end. Soon afterwards, a sudden burst of rain troubled the imperial camp.

'Wilt thou teach God the path of mercy?' Four years ago, in August 1574, Akbar had been reluctant, even a little shocked, perhaps, when farmers asked him to make it rain. Something fundamental had changed since then. In April 1578, as the storm thundered and his soldiers 'were distressed and complained', Akbar did not hesitate. He took a mirror and breathed upon it, then he put it in a fire. The clouds obeyed his command: the rainfall stopped.

. Michael H. Fisher describes the 'lengthy and contested process' of turning '*iqta*' land, that is, fiefs, into jagirs: 'In order to gain more direct data about actual yields, around 1575, the central administration resumed most such [iqta] grants, with the former grantee receiving in lieu a cash salary from the imperial treasury. Many former grant holders objected, particularly those whose incomes actually exceeded their official grant. About five years later, after the central administration had secured more accurate agricultural productivity figures . . .

it reissued most of the reassessed revenue assignments as jagirs – the term henceforth widely used for the temporary assignment of land revenue and other taxes from a designated territory. Jagirdars ("jagirholders") then collected these revenues or parceled them out among their followers.' See Michael H. Fisher, *A Short History of the Mughal Empire* (I.B. Tauris, 2016).

. Ali Anooshahr, 'The King Who Would Be Man: The Gender Roles of the Warrior King in Early Mughal History', *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, vol. 18, no. 3 (Cambridge University Press, 2008).

. Abu'l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 2, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990).

. It was his brother, Faizi, who took him home eventually. Abu'l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 5, trans. W.M. Thackston (Murty Classical Library of India, Harvard University Press, 2019).

. Nawab Samsam-ud-Daula Shah Nawaz Khan and his son Abdul Hayy, *The Maathir-ul-Umara: Biographies of the Muhammadan and Hindu Officers of the Timurid Sovereigns of India from 1500 to about 1780 AD*, trans. Henry Beveridge, revision, annotation and completion Baini Prashad, vols 1 and 2 (The Asiatic Society, 1941, 1952).

. Except his trousers, which were burnt, being too intimate, perhaps, to be handed down.